

FROM THE ARCHIVES
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Cover Story
God's Acre

These things happen in Kerala, God's Acre, hotwired for people who crave a little soul curry, who adopt the amazing inverse logic of an otherwise tumultuous state: *thalerade*, don't be upset; this is what the world is coming to.

It's as if in the past year or so, more than 600 years since Marco Polo described Kerala in purely commercial terms– 'There is in the great kingdom a great quantity of pepper and ginger and cinnamon and nuts of India'–setting off Christopher Columbus, among others, on a wild chase for the fabled Malabar, the world has woken up to a charm that the average Keralite takes for granted.

Every state has ideas, but few are developing them so consciously and yet with such seeming spontaneity as Kerala. Near Fort Kochi's sprawl of 100-300-year-old houses, a five-minute drive away from St Francis Church, where Vasco da Gama was buried before being shipped off to native Portugal, are everyday fish shops that have been transformed into the first step of a delightful food chain. The snapper, seerfish, squid and mussels– are made into as-you-wish dishes by nearby "you-buy-we-cook" shops.
-Sudeep Chakravarti

key architect of the campaign, writes in his book, *Branding India: An Incredible Story*, that the campaign was a 'brilliant springboard to showcase the myriad facets of Kerala's most powerful tourism product, Nature'. The key reason for the campaign's success, says Kant, was that "Kerala differentiated itself from the rest of the world. It didn't ape the West but rather went back to its roots".

In the 1990s, when the campaign started to catch on, Kerala's tourism infrastructure was limited (there was only one ITDC hotel in Kovalam). As the interest in Kerala surged, so did investments in infrastructure, leading to the creation of resorts and hotels across the state. Initially, it was the backpackers and budget travellers, who started arriving in droves which led to a strategic shift in brand positioning to attract high-value tourists from the West, says Kant, who is currently India's G20 Sherpa. Authentic experiences were curated around Kerala's 1,000-km-long backwaters, Ayurveda, spice plantations, wildlife and a wide array of local music and dance forms like Kathakali, Theyyam and Mohiniattam, he added.

The turning point came when Kerala received global recognition. *National Geographic Traveller* ranked it among the 10 exotic paradises of the world, featuring it under the headline 'Paradise Found'. Soon, celebrities like singer Paul McCartney, actor Richard Gere and India's then prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee began flocking to Kerala for vacations. Over time, the state created a tourist reputation distinct from that of the country.

The state campaign also had many firsts to its credit in tourism marketing. Kerala launched the first ever TV commercial by a state tourism board, titled 'Water Colours by God', made at a cost of Rs 70 lakh, and which aired on channels like Star Plus and Discovery. Since then, the campaign has evolved to include pop culture references, influencers and even memes to reach out to global audiences. Thanks to these efforts, Kerala earned Rs 43,621 crore from tourism in 2023, contributing some 12 per cent to its GDP. International tourist arrivals grew by a staggering 88 per cent, with 649,057 foreign visitors. Also, domestic tourist arrivals surged to 21.8 million, a jump of 15.9 per cent from the previous year.

The 'God's Own Country' campaign has stood the test of time, weathering storms such as the 9/11 terror attacks, the outbreak of Covid and the mega floods of 2018 and '19. In fact, in a state where the government changes almost every five years, the one constant is that it remains God's own country. ■

MORE THAN BEACHES

» **Established Kerala as one of the top travel destinations in the world**

» **Led to the development of more destinations, as well as the creation of tourism-related infrastructure such as hotels, resorts, airports**

» **Tourism now contributes 10-12% to state GDP**

» **Kerala's success inspired other states like Rajasthan and MP to adopt similar initiatives**

DID YOU KNOW?

One of Kerala's iconic tourist attractions, the *kettuvallams* or houseboats, were traditionally used to transport goods to various parts of the state. Crafted from wood of the jackfruit trees, 'kettuvallam' literally means a boat held together by ropes, a throwback to its earlier avatars